New Roots

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Project overview

The product:

NewRoots is designed to support immigrants who are currently living in the country without legal status by providing access to essential resources and step-by-step guidance toward legal residency. This platform empowers users with the tools and information they need to navigate complex legal processes while ensuring access to vital services such as legal aid, food, shelter, healthcare, and employment assistance.

Project duration:

March 9, 2025 is when I have started this project. I am hoping it will take a month long.

Preview of selected polished designs.

Project overview

The problem:

Many immigrants seeking legal residency face barriers such as lack of access to legal resources, difficulty finding essential services like food and shelter, language and literacy challenges, and fear of exposure due to their legal status. The process of navigating these obstacles is complex and fragmented, leaving immigrants without clear guidance or support.

The goal:

The goal of the NewRoots project is to provide immigrants with a user-friendly platform that centralizes legal resources and support services, overcoming language barriers, ensuring privacy, and simplifying the process of obtaining legal residency through clear, actionable steps.

Project overview

My role:

As the UX Designer, you will be responsible for creating an intuitive, user-friendly platform that addresses the needs of immigrants seeking legal residency.

As the Project Lead for Design, you will oversee the design process, ensuring that the app and website align with the project goals and are accessible to all users.

Responsibilities:

Conducted user research, created personas and user flows, developed wireframes and prototypes, designed visual UI elements, conducted usability testing, and collaborated with developers to ensure the platform was accessible and user-friendly.

Understanding the user

- User research
- Personas
- Problem statements
- User journey maps

User research: summary

For the NewRoots project, I conducted qualitative user research through interviews and surveys with immigrants seeking legal residency. Initially, I assumed that most users would have limited access to technology and prefer in-person resources, but the research revealed that many are tech-savvy and rely on smartphones for information. I also assumed that language barriers were the primary challenge, but further insights showed that navigating complex legal language was equally difficult. This shifted my design approach to focus on simplifying legal jargon and ensuring the platform was mobile-optimized, multilingual, and intuitive for all users.

User research: pain points

1

Pain point

Lack of Access to Legal Resources:
Many immigrants struggle to find affordable or accessible legal aid, often due to financial or language barriers. This pain point will guide the design to include clear, easily accessible legal information and links to free or low-cost legal services, ensuring users can easily find the help they need.

2

Pain point

Complex Legal Processes:
The immigration process is often difficult to navigate due to complex legal language and bureaucratic procedures. Moving forward, the design will prioritize simplifying the legal steps with easy-to-understand guides, visual aids, and multilingual support to make the process less overwhelming.

3

Pain point

Fear of Exposure or Legal Consequences:
Immigrants often hesitate to seek help due to fear of being reported or facing legal consequences. The design will focus on privacy and security, providing clear reassurances to users about data protection and confidentiality to help them feel safe using the platform.

4

Pain point

Fragmented Information on Support Services:
Essential resources like food, shelter, and healthcare are scattered across different platforms, making it difficult for immigrants to find comprehensive support. The design will consolidate these resources into one easy-to-navigate platform, allowing users to access everything they need in one place.

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Persona: **Maria (From Guatemala)**

Problem statement:

Maria is a 32-year-old undocumented mother from Guatemala who needs access to legal aid and housing resources because she faces the constant fear of deportation and struggles to find reliable support for her family in an unfamiliar legal system.

Maria Hernandez

Age: 32
Education: High school diploma
Hometown: Quetzaltenango, Guatemala
Family: Married with two children (ages 4 and 7)
Occupation: Housekeeper

"I just want a better life for my children, but I'm scared I'll never get there."

Goals

- To find legal resources that will help her navigate the immigration process.
- Secure stable housing and employment for her family.
- Gain legal status so she can live without the constant fear of deportation.

Frustrations

- Fear of being deported and separated from her family.
- Difficulty accessing legal aid and resources due to her undocumented status.
- Inability to find affordable housing or stable work.
- Language barriers and lack of understanding of the U.S. immigration system.

Maria fled Guatemala seeking safety and a better future for her family, but now faces the uncertainty of living in the U.S. without legal status. She is constantly worried about being found and deported. Despite working hard to support her family, she struggles to find reliable legal help and feels lost in the complex immigration system. Maria wants to find resources to adjust her status legally but is overwhelmed by the lack of information available in her native language. She uses the NewRoots app to connect with legal aid, find safe housing, and understand her options for becoming a legal resident, all while ensuring her children's safety and stability.

Google

Persona: **Ahmed (From Syria)**

Problem statement:

Ahmed is a 45-year-old overstayed student visa holder from Syria who needs clear, affordable legal guidance because he is confused by the immigration process and unable to find trustworthy resources to help him adjust his status and secure employment.

Ahmed Al-Farouq

Age: 45
Education: Bachelor's degree in Business Administration
Hometown: Aleppo, Syria
Family: Single, no children
Occupation: Freelance writer

"I never imagined that something as simple as paperwork could hold me back from a better life here."

Goals

- To find clear and affordable legal guidance to adjust his status.
- Secure stable employment and income to improve his quality of life.
- Understand the steps he needs to take to transition from a student visa overstay to legal residency.

Frustrations

- Confusion about the complex immigration laws and processes.
- Lack of affordable legal assistance.
- Fear of deportation due to his overstay.
- Feeling isolated and unsure about where to find trustworthy resources.

Ahmed arrived in the U.S. on a student visa but had to overstay due to financial difficulties. He quickly realized that the immigration process was more complicated than he expected. After his visa expired, Ahmed felt trapped—unable to work legally and unsure of what steps to take next. He feels anxious and uncertain about the future. Through the NewRoots app, Ahmed can finally access affordable legal advice, information on how to adjust his status, and resources to help him get back on his feet, all in one place. This empowers him to plan his next steps with more confidence.

Google

User journey map

Goals:

1. Simplify the Immigration Process:
   Both Maria and Ahmed need a seamless, understandable, and navigable system to guide them through their immigration journeys. As a UX designer, the goal is to create an experience that minimizes confusion at every stage — from finding resources to submitting applications. The key is to make the process as straightforward and intuitive as possible.
2. Enhance Accessibility:
   Given both personas are coming from diverse backgrounds and have varied educational levels, the UX design should focus on clear language, visual aids, and multilingual support to accommodate all users. Accessibility is a critical focus to ensure that users from different countries, with different needs, can access and interact with resources without barriers.
3. Prioritize Personalization:
   Maria and Ahmed both have unique immigration needs. The design should incorporate personalized experiences, such as location-based resources (e.g., legal centers near them) and tailored guides based on their specific legal or residency requirements. A customizable experience will help them feel empowered and confident in their actions.
4. Integrate Real-Time Updates and Notifications:
   As they navigate complex processes like appointments, document gathering, and legal applications, Maria and Ahmed will benefit from real-time notifications on next steps, document submissions, and updates on their applications. This helps reduce anxiety and frustration by ensuring that they are informed and can plan accordingly.
5. Create a Clear, Step-by-Step Process:
   Both personas need a clear roadmap of what steps to take in their journey, from initial research to final application. The goal is to break down the process into simple, bite-sized tasks with visual aids (like checklists or progress bars) that guide users through the journey without overwhelming them.

Thought Process:

1. User-Centric Design:
   The user experience needs to revolve around Maria and Ahmed's needs. The design must accommodate both personas by ensuring that their goals, frustrations, and specific needs are addressed. It's important to consider the diversity in their backgrounds and experiences and design a system that's flexible enough to cater to their individual challenges.
2. Empathy and Inclusion:
   Empathy plays a vital role in this project, particularly because Maria and Ahmed may experience feelings of anxiety, frustration, or fear when navigating the immigration process. The UX design should be mindful of these emotional responses and work toward providing an experience that makes them feel supported and guided every step of the way. This involves ensuring that the process is as transparent as possible, with plenty of resources to reduce uncertainty.

Persona: Maria

Goal: Find a legal resource center and begin the process of applying for legal residency.

ACTION	Determine legal resource center	Make appointment	Gather documentation	Attend appointment		
TASK LIST	Tasks A. Search online for legal aid options B. Read reviews or feedback on service C. Identify services that cater to immigrants	Tasks A. Call or email for appointment B. Confirm availability C. Schedule appointment	Tasks A. Make list of required documents B. Translate documents if necessary C. Organize documents to bring	Tasks A. Travel to the legal center B. Meet with legal expert C. Receive legal consultation D. Understand next steps for residency		
FEELING ADJECTIVE	• Overwhelmed • Anxious	• Hopeful, • Confused	• Stressed • Hopeful	• Relieved • Empowered	•	•
IMPROVEMENT OPPORTUNITIES	Clear search filters for immigrant services Verified resource list	Streamlined appointment process (online booking, reminders)	Checklist for required documents Language assistance tools	Digital follow-up resources (to track the process)		

Persona: Ahmed

Goal: Find a legal resource center to apply for legal residency and understand the necessary steps in the immigration process.

ACTION	Determine legal resource center	Make appointment	Gather documentation	Attend appointment	Start the legal application process	
TASK LIST	Tasks A. Search online for local legal aid centers B. Identify organizations that assist with immigration C. Confirm which services cater to his specific immigration situation	Tasks A. Call or email to request an appointment B. Confirm available dates and times C. Book an appointment that fits into his schedule	Tasks A. Make a list of required documents (passport, work permits, ID, etc.) B. Get necessary documents translated (if applicable) C. Organize the documents in preparation for the appointment	Tasks A. Travel to the legal aid center B. Meet with a legal consultant C. Discuss immigration status and potential next steps D. Receive advice on how to proceed with legal residency	Tasks A. Fill out the necessary application forms B. Submit forms and documents for review C. Follow up on the application status	
FEELING ADJECTIVE	• Anxious • Overwhelmed	• Hopeful • Cautious	• Stressed • Frustrated	• Nervous • Empowered	• Relieved • Optimistic	
IMPROVEMENT OPPORTUNITIES	Search filters based on specific immigration needs Verified list of legal resources in his area	Clear online booking system Automated reminders for appointments	Provide a checklist of required documents Translation assistance options available	Access to information about what to expect before the appointment Multiple languages available for consultation	A step-by-step guide to completing application forms Online status tracker for applications	

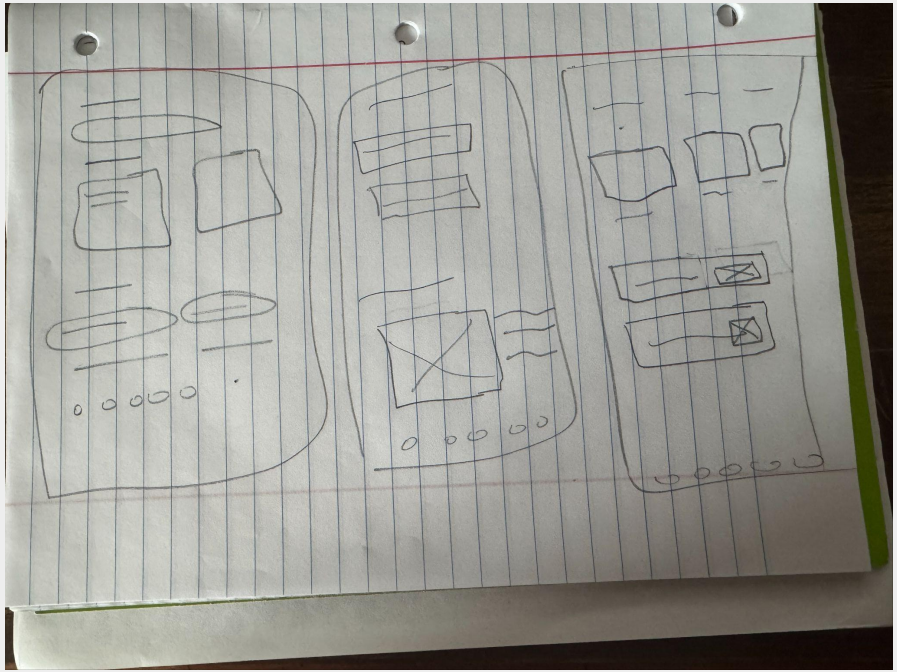
Google

Starting the design

- Paper wireframes
- Digital wireframes
- Low-fidelity prototype
- Usability studies

Paper wireframes

The goal is to explore multiple design possibilities and evaluate various solutions before identifying the most effective one. This approach ensures that the final design is user-friendly, accessible, and meets the needs of our target audience.



Digital wireframes

The goal of the wireframes is to create a simple, intuitive layout that guides users seamlessly through the platform while ensuring accessibility for all. The signup process is designed to be quick and easy, reducing barriers to entry and encouraging engagement. The homepage prioritizes clear navigation, directing users to essential services such as Legal Assistance, Job Support, and Essential Resources without overwhelming them with too much information at once. Each page follows a structured, minimalist approach, ensuring that key details—such as legal aid options, job application guidance, and critical community resources—are easily accessible. The overall thought process focuses on clarity, ease of use, and a hierarchy that places urgent user needs front and center, allowing them to find the help they need without frustration.

Easy navigation

Google

Digital wireframes

The high-fidelity wireframes bring the New Roots platform to life with an earthy-toned color palette, symbolizing growth, stability, and a fresh start. While maintaining the same intuitive layout, the addition of colors and imagery enhances visual engagement and usability. The homepage and navigation remain simple yet effective, guiding users effortlessly to Legal Assistance, Job Support, and Essential Resources. Thoughtful use of visuals helps convey warmth and trust, making the platform feel more welcoming. The design ensures clarity, accessibility, and a user-friendly experience, reinforcing the mission of providing support and guidance to those seeking a new beginning.

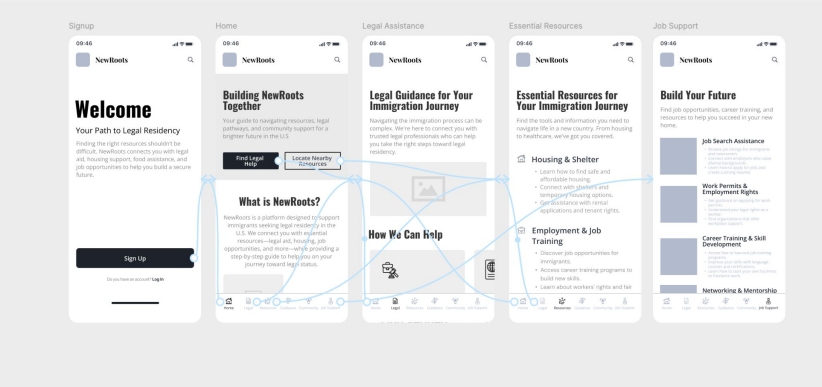
Warm tones used

Same easy navigation

Google

Low-fidelity prototype

The New Roots prototype demonstrates the user journey through a seamless and intuitive flow, starting from the Signup page and guiding users to key resources. Designed with clarity and accessibility in mind, the prototype connects the Home, Legal Assistance, Essential Resources, and Job Support pages, ensuring users can easily navigate the support they need. The low-fidelity prototype focused on structure and functionality, while the high-fidelity version enhances engagement with earthy tones, images, and refined interactions. This interactive model showcases how users can explore services, access critical information, and take steps toward building a stable future.



Usability study: findings

To ensure New Roots provided a seamless and accessible experience, we conducted two rounds of usability studies. These studies focused on evaluating navigation, clarity of information, and overall user engagement. Participants interacted with the prototype to identify pain points and areas for improvement.

Round 1 findings

1. Users found the Signup process unclear, with some struggling to understand what information was required.
2. The Legal Assistance page lacked direct contact options, making it difficult for users to take immediate action.
3. Some participants felt the navigation was not intuitive, particularly when switching between Essential Resources and Job Support.

Round 2 findings

1. Improved Signup instructions led to better user comprehension, but some still hesitated due to wording confusion.
2. Adding clear call-to-action buttons on the Legal Assistance page significantly improved usability.
3. Users appreciated the earthy-toned design and imagery, but some suggested minor layout refinements for better readability.

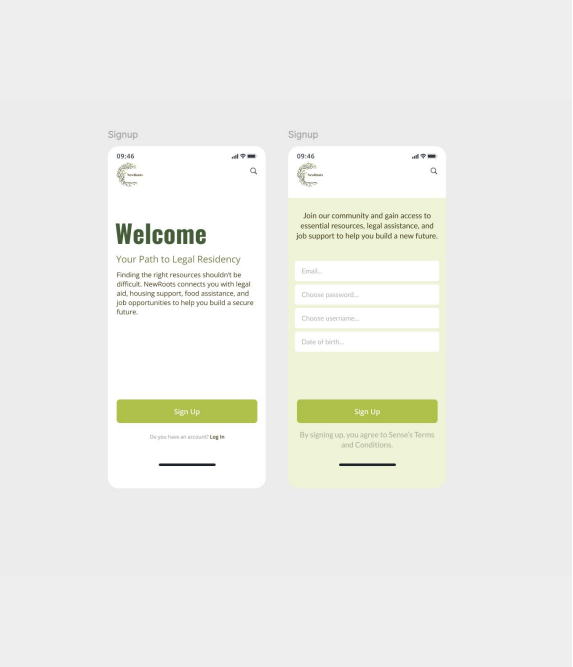
Refining the design

- Mockups
- High-fidelity prototype
- Accessibility

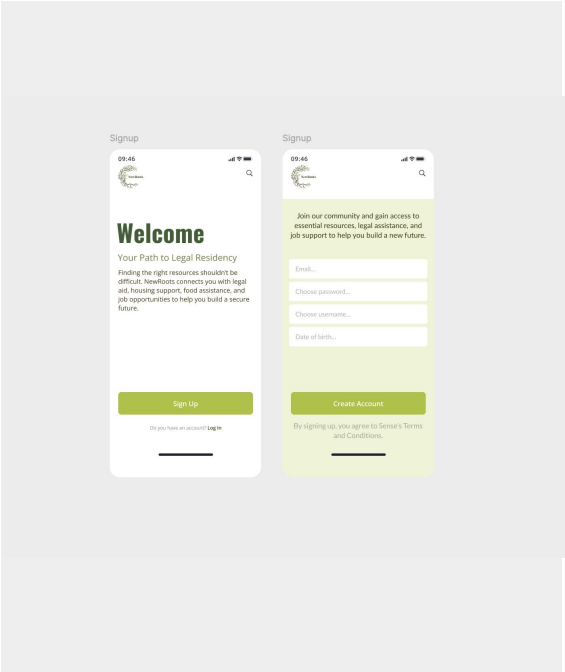
Mockups

Something as simple as changing Sign up to Create account was done because it created confusion for the user

Before usability study



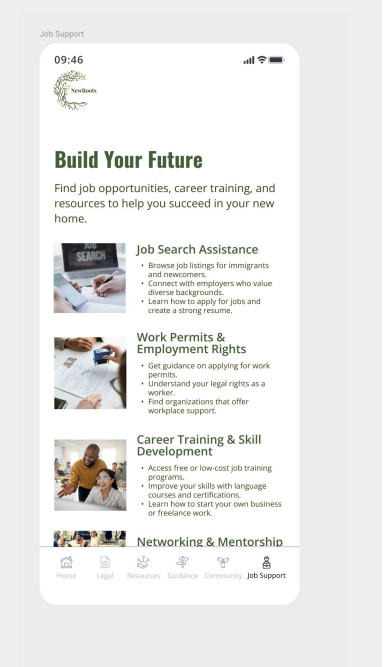
After usability study



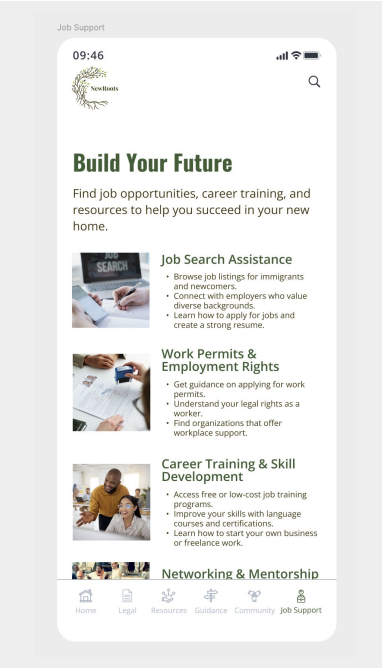
Mockups

Adding a search bar and colorizing the menu button to make sure the user knew what page they were on and still stayed with branding colors.

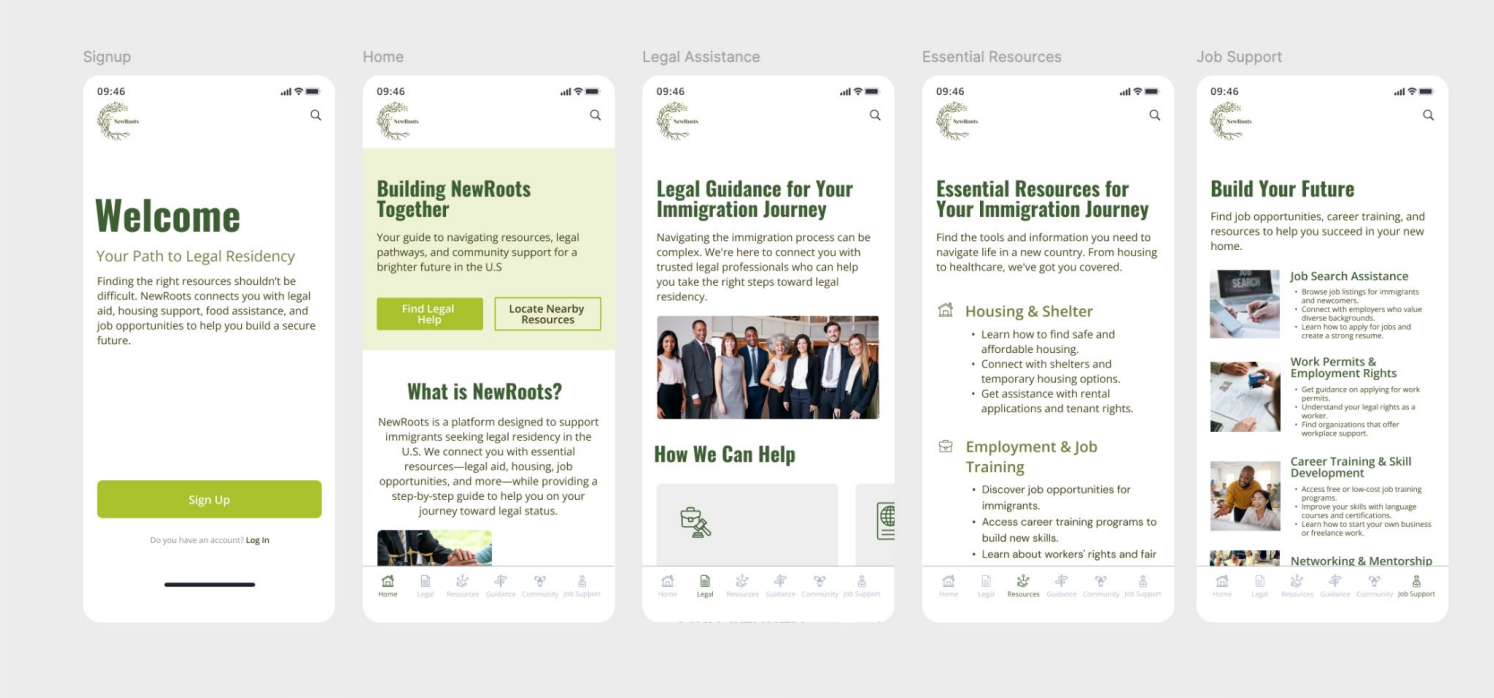
Before usability study



After usability study



Mockups



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High-fidelity prototype

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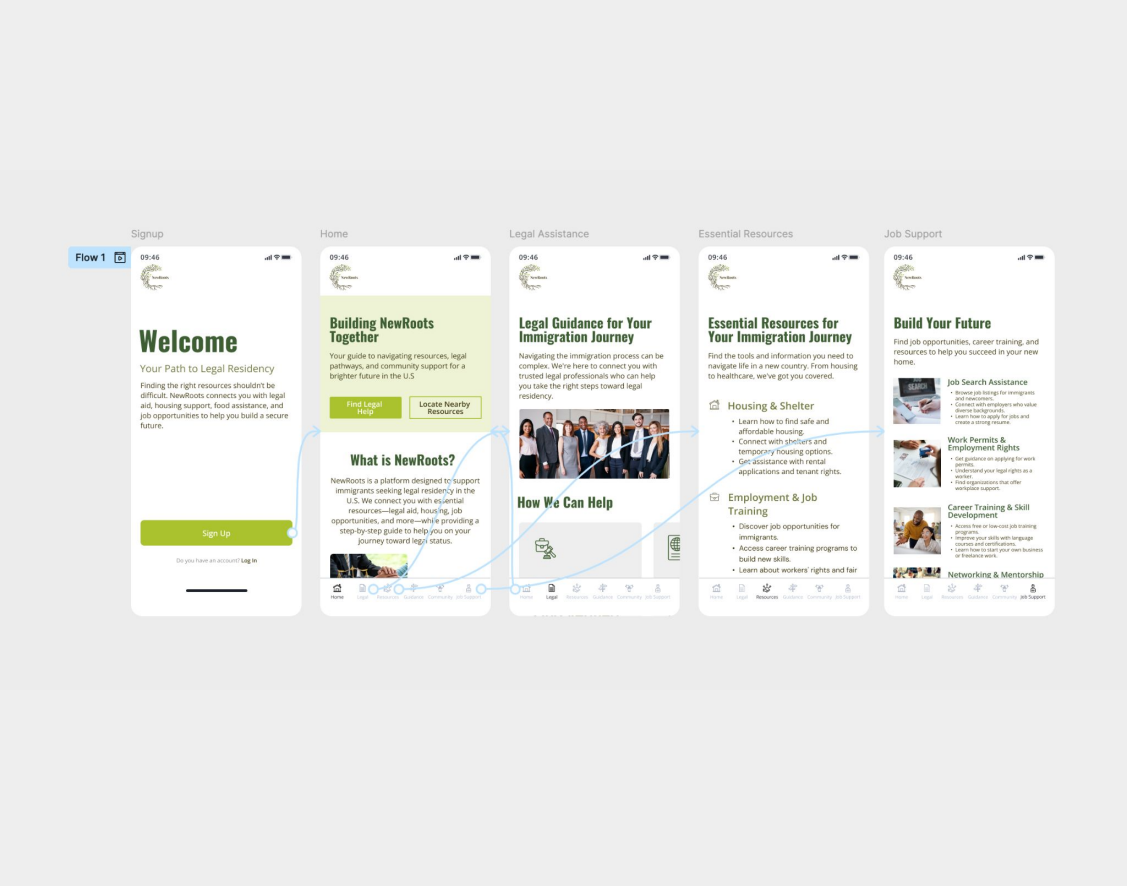

Google

Accessibility considerations

1

I tried to consider text size and contrast. I wanted to make sure the user had no issues reading the app

2

The app should be compatible with screen readers, allowing users with visual impairment to access the app's content.

3

Users with color blindness should have no issues with the color scheme.

Going forward

- Takeaways
- Next steps

Takeaways

Impact:

These improvements demonstrate how thoughtful design choices can create a more user-friendly and inclusive digital experience.

What I learned:

Throughout this project, I learned that even small design changes can have a significant impact on the overall user experience.

Google

Next steps

1

Figure out if there are any other areas that need to be worked on.

2

Need to keep testing the functionality

3

Package my project

Google

Let’s connect!

Thank you for reviewing my work with King Soopers app.

If you would like to see more, or would like to get in touch, my contact information is provided below:

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